

“Yoga helps concentrate all your energies. It brings you peace and calm, and your concentration abilities are enhanced. What I have come to realise is that during the day yoga helps bring clarity to my mind. There is so much information overload on any given day and I feel yoga helps me cut through the clutter and concentrate on what is important,” explains Soni.

For Lexus India, its highest ever sales were achieved in 2022, since its inception in 2017. Soni says SUVs are the flavour of the season and that the average age of the luxury buyer is going down. Unlike earlier, when your first car was a mass-market car, or even a second-hand car, and you gradually progressed to a luxury car, today the first car is a luxury car, he says.

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While Lexus introduced the NX at the beginning of 2022 and LX at the end of the year, it launched the RX— another SUV—at the Auto Expo in January. From a global perspective, Lexus plans to shift completely to electric vehicles by 2035. “You will see more electric vehicles coming from us,” says Soni. In 2022, Lexus added five service points to its seven existing guest experience centres. This helps it cover nearly 85 per cent of the market where Lexus vehicles are in demand. **BT**

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HOWZZAT Sairaj Dhond enjoys booking big stadiums and playing cricket there

ON THE FIELD

**Cricket keeps me alive, says Sairaj Dhond,
Founder & CEO of Wakao Foods**

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

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“Cricket is religion,” says 34-year-old Sairaj Dhond, Founder & CEO of Wakao Foods, a Goa-based sustainable start-up that offers ready-to-cook and ready-to-eat products in the Indian market. Dhond represented the state of Goa in cricket tournaments during his school and college days. However, as is the case with most people, life took over and cricket took a back seat.

Over the past few years, he has rekindled his love for the sport. “I am doing well now professionally so I have the leverage to again explore the game. I realised there were several people like me,” says Dhond, who now plays cricket for several clubs in Goa. “We now play Members Leagues’ against other clubs.” Dhond has played in London, Paris and Dubai, and also in stadiums in Dharamshala and Dehradun. “We are like those wannabe international cricketers,” laughs Dhond. “We could never get an opportunity to play in these stadiums. Today we can afford to book them and play in them,” he smiles.

Dhond explains how this is now an organised sector where companies book stadiums where international matches are held and

organise tournaments for people from across India to play. Teams from Delhi, Mumbai, Goa, etc., participate and play against each other. “This is something that just keeps me alive.”

For Dhond, sports was an integral part of his growing-up days. His mother is a national-level basketball player. “I play over ten kinds of sports but cricket is my first love.”

Dhond is a serial entrepreneur—Wakao is his fourth venture. He is a lawyer by training but quit after practising for a year and joined his family hospitality business where he lasted six months. He then set up his first venture, which was for solar heating installations. He then moved to LED lighting, and after that he restored an old heritage home in Goa and sold it before starting Wakao Foods two years ago. Wakao is bootstrapped with Dhond owning 100 per cent of the company. Its products are currently available across the country through the online model. Going forward, Dhond wants to set up the QSR model. **BT**

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